



DESIGN CREATIVE AND A CHILD-FRIENDLY LEARNING ENVIRONMENT

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3.1 INTRODUCTION

You must have studied about the concept of curriculum, curriculum planning, curriculum implementation, various pedagogical / instructional methods and techniques, various instructional media and resources. However, in our common experience, we see that inspite of a common curriculum, textbooks, instructional methods and media, some schools or some teachers are able to achieve the aims and goals of education holistically. What are the reasons why some teachers or schools are considered to be better than others?

One of the most important reasons can be attributed to creating a positive and child-friendly learning environment. The environment in which the children are learning plays a very crucial role in not just learning, but also in shaping them as a person and as a future citizen of society. In this chapter, we will discuss the concept of learning environment, its various aspects and how can we create a conducive and positive environment for our children. Let the journey begin!

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2.2 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After completing this chapter, the learner:

- illustrates the characteristics of a child-friendly learning environment;
- distinguishes between effective indoor and outdoor space designs;
- analyses environmental influences on children's engagement, safety, and creativity;
- evaluates the teacher's role in creating, adapting, and facilitating learning environments;
- designs a model layout (indoor or outdoor) that integrates elements of play, creativity, and inclusivity, aligned with child-centred pedagogy.

3.3 LEARNING ENVIRONMENT

When we say Learning Environment, what do we actually mean by it? It means an environment which facilitates learning. A learning environment comprises of physical, psychological, social and cultural spaces created in order to facilitate learning. The learning environment (LE) comprises the psychological, social, cultural, and physical setting in which learning occurs and in which experiences and expectations are co-created among its participants (Rusticus et al., 2023).

School-age children, especially younger children, are affected by their overall environment; and therefore, it is our job to ensure that children get an enriching and safe environment which is conducive to their overall development and learning needs. Learning happens as a result of the interaction of learners with their environment. The external environment interacts with the inner capacities of learners, helping them create or construct meanings for their own self. That is why, learning is an active process. Generally, in a layperson's terms, learning environment is understood in terms of creating physical spaces, but we as educators must understand that our physical environment is important; but equally important are the other dimensions listed below:

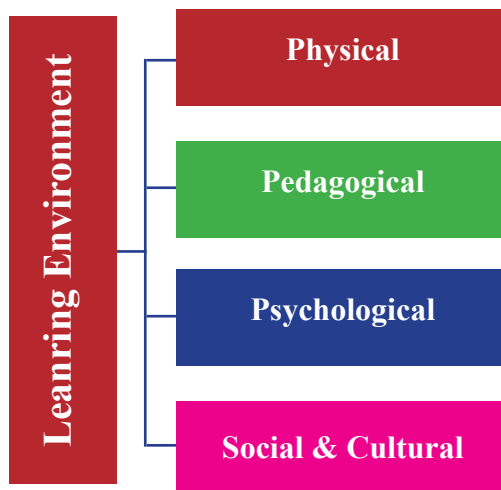


Fig. 3.1: Dimensions of Learning Environment

And when we are talking about a Child-friendly Learning Environment (CFLE), we basically refer to learning spaces which foster holistic development and well-being among young learners. The real difference between an average school or a teacher and a good school or a teacher is basically how the learning experiences are shaped up by the school or the teachers. In spite of having the same curriculum, same books and learning resources, an average teacher may not be able to make of difference in the lives of learners; however, an insightful teacher understands the importance of positive environment and will create positive and joyful learning experiences which maximise learning but also will result in creating students who have an all-round personality development.

The environments need to be created in such a manner that they arouse curiosity and inquisitiveness among students. The spaces should make them feel safe, welcome, ready to learn- spaces which they can call their own and can identify with. The kinds of learning environments/ spaces are briefly described below:

1. **Physical Learning Environment:** It refers to the tangible aspects of the classrooms and school, including their design, layout, furniture, lighting, temperature, air quality, and access to resources. For primary learners, it means bright, colourful, inviting spaces which facilitate free movements, group work, activities, and collaborative learning. A child-friendly physical environment will include age-appropriate furniture, areas for group activities, a play area, individual work stations. These areas need to have appropriate light, good ventilation, and be free from noise pollution. Such an environment can foster a sense of peace and joyful learning among learners. The physical learning environment can be divided as Indoor and Outdoor environment, which we will discuss in detail shortly.

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2. **Psychological Learning Environment:** It refers to providing psychological and emotional safe spaces for children taking into account their feelings, personality, stages of development and self-perception. Child-friendly spaces should allow a 'safe' space for children where they feel comfortable asking questions, expressing themselves, and making mistakes as a part of growing up. Teachers, who understand child psychology can provide a supportive and a facilitative environment. An environment which makes the child feel threatened, scared, or intimidated is detrimental to their development. It is said that 'childhood does not end with childhood, it continues throughout the entire lifespan of a person'. This statement highlights the permanence of childhood's psychological, emotional, and existential impact. Childhood is not merely a phase to be outgrown but a foundational and continuous part of who we are—manifesting in memories, emotions, patterns of behaviour, and the enduring search for meaning and connection. Therefore, it is vital to create an environment which leaves a positive impact on the young, impressionable minds of the students.
3. **Social and Cultural Learning Environment:** It encompasses providing a cordial environment in which focuses on quality of relationships and interactions between peers, students and teachers and with the community. It also refers to an inclusive environment which not only accommodates diversity but celebrates diversity among learners. It aims at cultivating a sense of community and belongingness among learners. For primary level children, a good social learning environment would include opportunities for play, collaborative tasks, group projects etc. The focus needs to be on fostering communication skills and developing skills like listening, caring, sharing, conflict resolution, tolerance, empathy, and respect for diversity. Therefore, the learning environment would involve creating spaces which are multicultural, including celebrating various cultural traditions, festivals, foods etc. It encourages students to share their unique cultural perspectives, fostering mutual respect, reducing stereotypes, and preparing them to be empathetic global citizens who appreciate the richness of different cultures.
4. **Pedagogical Learning Environment:** It implies creating spaces and instructional materials which are based on sound philosophical and psychological principals, curriculum theory and inclusive education literature. The learning environment must take into consideration the requirement of following a multitude of pedagogical approaches like play-based learning, activity-based learning, inquiry-based learning,

constructivist learning, experiential learning and inclusive education. Teachers need to adopt methods and techniques of teaching that makes learning 'Joyful' for children and make them curious and inquisitive. The focus has to be on inculcating creative and thinking abilities among children so that they are able to experience knowledge, relate to others, and develop as learners and individuals. It is not a luxury but a foundational necessity for a meaningful and transformative education.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 3.1

1. What are the main components of a Learning Environment? If you are a teacher of a primary level class, how will you create a child-friendly learning environment?
2. What components of Learning Environment are in the hand of a teacher and what components are beyond her agency?

3.4 PHYSICAL LEARNING ENVIRONMENT

The Physical Learning Environment refers to the tangible setting in which learning occurs. It encompasses both indoor and outdoor spaces within a school, including the school building, classrooms, furniture, storage units, open areas, lawns, activity zones, play areas, green spaces, and natural surroundings. These elements together create a holistic environment that supports the physical, emotional, and cognitive development of learners.

The recent experience of the COVID-19 pandemic has profoundly impacted various aspects of human life, with children's learning and development among the most affected. Despite the widespread implementation of online classes, evidence across countries indicates that children's educational progress and overall growth suffered significant setbacks. Although access to digital content, books, and teacher-led sessions continued, what was noticeably absent was the human and relational dimension of learning. The lack of in-person interaction and the absence of a rich physical and psychological learning environment led to a substantial void in the children's educational experience—highlighting the irreplaceable role of embodied, sensory, and socially contextualized learning that a physical learning environment provides. We will now discuss the Indoor and the outdoor learning environments in detail:



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3.4.1 Indoor Learning Environment

A well-designed indoor classroom environment is critical for a child's learning and development. The physical features of the space directly influence a child's behaviour, engagement, and ability to focus. These features influence not only **academic outcomes** but also **emotional and behavioural development**, especially in early childhood and primary education. The following points need to be considered:

1. Classrooms should be well-lit, with sufficient natural daylight and artificial lighting to prevent eye strain and enhance students' attention and comfort.
2. Proper ventilation systems should be in place to ensure a constant flow of fresh air, which helps enhance students' physical health and cognitive performance.
3. Temperature should be regulated so that children do not feel too much heat or cold.
4. Effective sound insulation and noise reduction measures should be used to minimise external noise, using soft furnishings, acoustic panels, or carpets.
5. Spaces and furniture available in the classroom should be flexible so that they may be rearranged to accommodate different instructional methods (like individual and group work, teachers' instructions, demonstrations, dramatizations, free play) and media (like pictures, charts, models, real objects, ICT tools, movies). Also, the space should allow for free movement.
6. The furniture should be child-size and child-friendly to ensure a sense of belongingness on the part of children. Also, it should be child-safe, meaning, furniture which prevents injuries. The furniture may have rounded edges, soft corners and edges, strong base to prevent it from toppling over and made from non-toxic materials.
7. The walls of children's classrooms should be adorned with colourful, inviting, and intriguing charts and materials. These play a pivotal role in creating a vibrant learning space that instils a powerful sense of belongingness in every child.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 3.2

Compare the two pictures and write which classroom environment is more effective. Compare the points on the basis of physical, psychological, social and pedagogical basis:



Picture 1: (Source : AI-Generated Image)



Picture 2: (Source : AI-Generated Image)

POINTS OF COMPARISON:

	Physical environment	Psychological environment	Social environment	Pedagogical environment
Picture 1				
Picture 2				

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3.4.2 Outdoor Learning Environment

Outside learning environment refers to spaces outside the classroom including verandahs, play grounds, the building structure, a herbal garden, swimming pool, and open spaces outside the classrooms. These spaces are important to provide a rich, stimulating and enriching environment to children through physical activity and interaction with nature. The following points summarise the importance of playing in outdoor spaces:

1. Open spaces allow children to run, jump, climb, balance themselves and play various sports and games, which are instrumental in developing their gross and fine motor skills as well as physical as well as mental fitness.
2. Since many sports are team based, they also help in developing social and emotional skills, develop sportsmanship, independence and confidence, resulting in a healthier and well-rounded individuals.
3. Ample outdoor spaces help reduce screen time for children, which is a major challenge faced by societies all over the world.
4. These spaces also provide adequate opportunities for children to come in touch with nature including flora and fauna, so that their environmental sensitivity is developed.
5. These spaces are designed to give wings to children's innate tendency for playing. Playing in the open exposes them to the sun, which is a natural source of Vitamin D.

In effect, we can conclude that playing in the open, often referred to as outdoor play, is incredibly important for children's development and well-being. It offers a wide range of benefits across physical, cognitive, social, and emotional domains that indoor environments simply cannot fully replicate.

The following points need to be considered when designing the outdoor environment for children:

- a) **Risk-free area:** A thorough check-up should be conducted for ruling out any kind of security hazard, like sharp objects, poisonous plants, exposed wires, untended water bodies, unstable structures etc. Also, care should be taken to define the border of the area and there should be no hidden corners. It should offer a clear view of the area. Since outdoors are not only about sports ground, but also includes pathways,



gardens and other open areas, risk assessment of every area is extremely important. Only non-toxic materials such as paints, finishes and swings should be used.

- b) **Multipurpose design:** the design should be such that it is possible for children to use it as a ground for sports like badminton, cricket and football, as well as other games like peek-a-boo, hide-and-seek and ring-around-a-Rosie.
- c) **Types of swings/ 'Jhulas':** There should be different types of swings or 'Jhulas'.
- d) **Bright and colourful look:** Children are attracted by colours, so the spaces should be bright and colourful.
- e) **Space for greenery:** various kinds of trees and plants including herbal plants, need to be grown so that environmental sensitivity is developed. Also, children need to be encouraged to 'adopt' a plant and take care of it on a regular basis.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 3.3

In the pictures given below, critically analyse the outdoor environment depicted:



Picture 1: (Source : AI generated Image)

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Picture 2: (Source : AI generated Image)



Picture 3: (Source : AI generated Image)



Picture 4: (Source : AI generated Image)

Answer:

Picture 1	Picture 2	Picture 3	Picture 4

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3.4.3 Psychological Learning Environment

As educators, it's vital to remember that a child's early years are incredibly important. This is a crucial time when their self-concept (i.e. how they see and understand themselves) is really taking shape. Every single experience they have, even the small ones that might seem unimportant to us, plays a huge role in building their personality. Children need to feel good about themselves and experience a sense of accomplishment. These feelings are what truly mould their self-concept and overall personality. We know that a child who feels good about who they are is much more likely to grow into a balanced and happy individual.

Consequently, establishing a psychologically positive learning environment is of paramount importance for the holistic development and comprehensive growth of learners. Kellough and Kellough (1999) have given the following points for establishing a positive environment:

1. Criticise the behaviours not the person. For example, instead of saying, "Rahul, you are so disruptive! You always talk when I'm teaching.", the teacher can try "Rahul, when you talk while I'm teaching, it makes it hard for others to hear and learn. Please raise your hand if you have something to say".

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2. Prejudice or partiality in any form is totally unfair on the part of any teacher. An inclusive environment needs to be developed.
3. Attend to the classroom's physical appearance and comfort, as it affects the emotional aspects of students. A classroom's physical comfort and appearance directly influence students' emotions and overall mood. A well-designed space positively impacts how students feel and engage.
4. Be an interesting person, as well as an optimistic and enthusiastic teacher
5. Encourage students to set high yet realistic goals for themselves, and then facilitate them in attaining those goals.
6. Help students develop their interactive and cooperative learning skills. This will go a long way in developing the social and emotional aspects of their personality.
7. Involve students in every aspect of their learning, including the planning of their learning activities. This will develop sense of ownership and responsibility towards their own learning.
8. Make learning fun, as far as possible.
9. Recognise and reward true positive behaviours, no matter how small they may be. This will go a long way in developing children with a good self-concept and self-esteem.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 3.4

Critically analyse the below scenario, what changes would you suggest to improve the overall classroom environment?

A Classroom Scenario:

Ms. Rita, though experienced teacher, is often stressed and overwhelmed. She tends to use a stern, authoritative tone, frequently raising her voice. Her feedback is often critical and personal. For example, if a child makes a mistake, she might say, "You're not listening, are you? Why do you always make silly errors?" She rarely offers praise for effort, only for perfect outcomes. Her classroom rules are rigid, with little room for student input or choice. Consequences for misbehaviour are immediate and sometimes public (e.g., publicly shaming a child for fidgeting). She assigns tasks without much explanation of their purpose, often focusing solely on rote memorization. There's little opportunity for collaborative work or creative expression, as she prefers quiet, individual seatwork.



Classroom Atmosphere: The physical space is functional. Desks are arranged in strict rows. Walls are bare, or covered with old, faded charts. Natural light is minimal, and the room often feels cold. There's no designated cozy corner or space for independent exploration.

Student Behaviour:

- Students appear disengaged. Many stare blankly, doodle, or fidget.
- Participation is low, with children hesitant to ask questions or share ideas for fear of being wrong or criticized.
- Children seem anxious and fearful of making mistakes. Some withdraw, avoiding eye contact. Others are distracted, at times engaging in poking, fighting, or playing their own games in class
- Many children exhibit low self-confidence. They believe they are “not smart” or “always messy.” They show little initiative and are hesitant to take on challenges.
- Peer interactions are out of the classroom. There's little cooperation and fierce competition among some children. Some children resort to withdrawing from other activities like playing, because they want Ms. Sharma's elusive approval.

3.4.4 Social and Cultural Learning Environment

Building an appropriate social and cultural environment for children at the primary stage would include thinking about the entire web of relationships, interactions, classroom rules, beliefs, customs, and communication styles that are followed throughout the session. We know that human beings are social beings and therefore, the social and cultural environment is the background against which all the learning takes place. It also has a huge impact on the personality development of children. Lev Vygotsky, a prominent Soviet psychologist, in his Sociocultural Theory of Development, has said that human development, including learning, is deeply embedded in social and cultural interaction. He highlighted that children learn primarily through their interactions with more knowledgeable others (parents, teachers, peers) and through the tools and signs (like language) of their culture. Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Systems Theory (1979) states that environmental systems, from the immediate family and classroom to the broader community and cultural values, interconnect and

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influence a child's development. Therefore, entire milieu of the socio-cultural environment needs extra care and attention, especially in case of primary level children, since they are in a crucial stage and whatever they experience, they will imbibe and, this in turn, will stay with them for a long period of time, if not their entire life. Therefore, teachers need to be extra cautious with their language and behaviours, so that the children do not 'learn' any form of unwanted learning from their behaviours. The spectrum of social and cultural environment can be shown in the form of the following diagram:

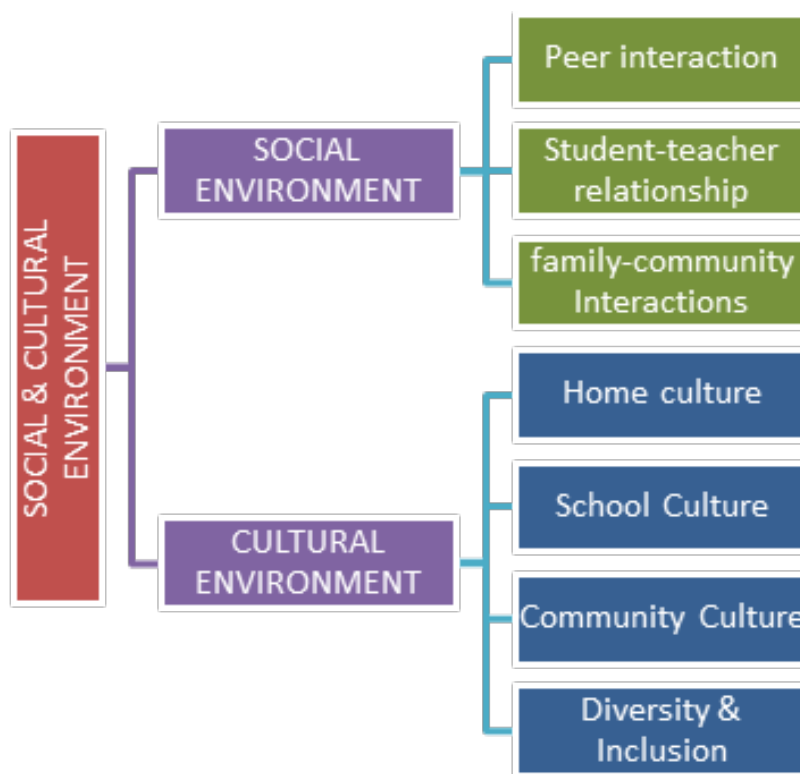


Fig. 3.2: Social & Cultural Environment

3.4.4.1 Social Environment:

It is the responsibility of the school, teachers, and family to provide a stable, consistent, cordial and positive social environment to children. The following pointers may be helpful:

1. **Building a foundation of mutual trust and empathy:** A teacher needs to 'know' about each child in her class, therefore, it is a good idea to take out time to really know your students by making them present information about themselves. Each and every student is to be treated with respect. As



mentioned earlier, criticise the behaviours and not the student. The actions of students have to be separated from the student.

2. **Incorporating Contemplative practices like Mindfulness:** Research studies have pointed out the relevance of starting Mindfulness practices right from the very beginning. Children can be introduced to simple practices like mindful breathing, deep listening and mindful eating at an early stage and later on, children can be exposed to different meditation techniques for their over-all well-being. Also, these practices have been recognised to inculcate Higher Order Thinking Skills (HOTS) and Metacognitive abilities.
3. **Building an Inclusive environment:** Efforts are to be made by teachers build an inclusive classroom environment, so that children learn ideals of equality right from the beginning. For this, teachers, themselves, need to free themselves from biases, prejudices and other forms of discrimination; which invariably creep in our language and actions inadvertently. Teachers as reflective practitioners need to consciously think about their behaviours and language, which may reinforce certain prejudices, that children, like sponges, may absorb these ideas unknowingly.
4. **Fostering a sense of Belonging:** The teacher needs to inculcate a sense that this space belongs to them. For this, the children may be involved in decorating their own classroom with charts, pictures and a chart of their birthdays. The teacher may invite them to design their work space as per their requirements. This will give a sense of ownership for the classroom and other spaces.
5. **Gender sensitivity:** Teachers need to be extra careful with the language they use and the kinds of tasks that are assigned to boys and girls. It should be noted that boys and girls at the primary level do not differ much as far as physical strength and other parameters are concerned; however teachers generally tend to allocate 'certain' kinds of work to boys and certain other types of work to girls, which reinforces the already established stereotypical gender norms.
6. **Positive Interactions:** Classroom interactions must be positive so children feel good about being there. While teachers might sometimes believe that harsh or insulting remarks about a student's behaviour are helpful, this can actually backfire. Such comments can deeply wound a child's self-esteem and self-concept, leading to lasting negative impacts on their mind.

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7. **Fostering spirit of cooperation and collaboration:** Cultivating cooperation and collaboration is key to a harmonious classroom. When children work together, share ideas, and support one another's learning, it builds strong social bonds, teaches teamwork, and helps everyone succeed by using their diverse strengths. This also nurtures crucial social and emotional skills; therefore, teachers should regularly integrate cooperative and collaborative tasks, such as group projects, case studies, or creating shared charts and pictures. It's also vital for teachers to guide children in resolving conflicts and differences of opinion amicably using socially accepted methods. This approach develops their communication and negotiation skills, teaching them to be assertive rather than aggressive in their interactions.
8. **Classroom Management:** Effective classroom management is the process of organizing and conducting a classroom so that it maximises student learning. It is very important to establish and maintain classroom control, by way of classroom procedures and rules, and to follow these consistently. The procedures and rules must be consistent with school policy; also, the consequences for not following established procedures must be understood by students.

3.4.4.2 Cultural Environment

The children need to be exposed to various cultures from the very beginning, so that they may shape up as a global citizen. At the same time, attention needs to be given to their knowing about their own culture and take pride in knowing it. Therefore, a plethora of experiences need to be built so that children may grow up embedded in their cultures and at the same time, are aware of, and appreciate the multitude of diverse culture, language, traditions and languages. The following points need consideration:

1. **Celebrating diversity actively:** Organise events where children can share aspects of their own family's culture, such as traditional clothing, songs, simple recipes, or family stories. Also learn about major festivals and traditions from various cultures represented in the classroom and globally (e.g., Diwali, Eid, Christmas, Holi, etc.). This can involve sharing stories, music, art, and even simple food items associated with these celebrations, and organising class events based on these themes.



- 2. Integrating diverse cultures into the curriculum:** This would mean showing respect to all languages and cultures from the children come. Encourage them to speak words and phrases from their native tongue and culture. Also encouraging students to come up with stories and unique customs and present them in the class. There may be events around diverse cultures e.g. Cultural Foods, Cultural festivals, Cultural dresses and Cultural stories. Similar themes may also be shown by way of pictures around the classroom.
- 3. Involving families and communities:** The school may involve the local community and families by celebrating or organising events like grand-parents day, cultural fests, community service



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 3.5

Critically examine the below scenarios and write your views about the kind of impact will these have on children and their psyche. What would be your suggestions for Mr. Desai?

A Classroom Scenario:

Mr. Desai is a dedicated and caring Class III teacher, deeply committed to her students' academic progress. He regularly organises different kinds of classroom activities for children to participate. His students love her and he is quite popular with parents also.

Scene 1: During a collaborative Science activity on simple tools: Mr. Desai observes a group of boys struggling to tie a knot securely. He walks over and says, *"Come on, boys, you're so good with building things! This is easy for you, you're natural engineers. Show the girls how it's done!"* Later, he sees a group of girls meticulously measuring and drawing their designs. She comments, *"Girls, your drawing is so neat and tidy, just wonderful! That's why you're so good at keeping things looking good."*

Scene 2: The school is organising a Fete cum Exhibition and all students are involved in displaying their work. There is a lot of work to be done. He says to boys, *"Come on all boys, move the furniture so that displays can be put up nicely"* and he says to girls *"Girls, you are so good with drawings and craft work, let's make some beautiful charts and drawings to be put up on the walls of our classroom"*.

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Scene 3: During a class project on “Cleanliness in Our Community.” Students are to draw posters showing good hygiene practices and how people can keep their surroundings clean. He emphasises the importance of a clean environment for health. During the explanation, Mr. Desai brings up examples. *“Think about clean houses, like the ones you see in nice neighbourhoods. Everyone wears clean clothes, and there’s no litter around.”* He then looks towards a group of children, some of whom come from a nearby informal settlement (slum area), and adds, *“We all need to try harder, don’t we? Especially when we go outside our school, let’s remember to keep everything tidy, so our whole city looks good. Some areas need more help with this”.*

3.4.5 Pedagogical Learning Environment

Dictionary meaning of pedagogy is the art and science of the methods and activities of teaching. A Pedagogical Learning Environment is a structured environment designed to facilitate effective teaching and learning. It is based on sound Philosophical and Psychological principles. It involves carefully considering the learner’s needs, creating a supportive and engaging atmosphere, and employing appropriate teaching strategies to promote deep understanding and knowledge construction. Therefore, creating a good pedagogical learning environment encompass curricular design, instructional methods, assessment strategies. It means designing the overall framework within which the teaching and learning takes place. Since you must have discussed most these topics in other chapters and units, here we will just bring a few pointers:

1. **Learner-centred approaches:** the Instructional or Teaching approaches to be adopted should learner-centric. Since we are talking of teaching primary children, the focus has to be on the processes of learning rather than the final products of learning. A teacher needs to use a variety of Instructional Methods and approaches to facilitate learning.
2. **Active Learning:** the children have actively involved in the process of their learning. Passive learning translates to ‘no learning’.
3. **Using Constructivist approaches:** Since we understand that each learner constructs his/her own learning, the role of a teacher is to be a facilitator and let children construct their own learning based on their own experiences and interaction with the environment.



4. **Effective use of Technology:** The children are digital natives and are extremely comfortable with technology. We as teachers, need to imbibe in them a sense of judicious use of technology. Children, should not be over-exposed, while at the same time should understand to use it as an efficient tool. Also, many times it is seen that schools subscribe to various LMS (Learning Management Systems), in which a teacher is required to play the lesson and children are supposed to watch. Such options which take away the agency from the teacher are not good, neither for the students not for the teacher.
5. **Use of various methods and tools of assessment for holistic assessment:** Teachers need to make use of various methods like Performance-based assessment, Portfolios, Projects, Collaborative Learning for assessing children holistically. Rather than relying only on tests, the teachers must be comfortable with making and using various tools such as Rubrics, Rating scales, anecdotal records, observation schedules etc. Assessments has to be a judicious mix of ‘Assessment of Learning’, ‘Assessment for Learning’ and ‘Assessment as Learning’.
6. **Real world connections:** learning has to be placed in real world situation which means focus has to be on applications in real life and making it more engaging and relevant.
7. **Focus on Holistic development:** Education traditionally has focused on cognitive development. However, we now realise fully well that education is overall development i.e. cognitive, physical, emotional, social, psychological, aesthetic, moral and spiritual aspects of students’ personalities. And we cannot afford to ignore even a single aspect of any of these spheres.

In brief we can conclude that pedagogical learning environment is a carefully designed ecosystem which supports and enhances learning and levels of learning among our children.

3.5 IMPORTANCE OF CREATING A POSITIVE LEARNING ENVIRONMENT

From the above discussion, we can come to the conclusion that creating a positive learning environment is extremely important for ensuring proper growth and development for our young learners.



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Design Creative and A Child-Friendly Learning Environment

- **Boosts Overall Development:** It's essential for children's complete growth, helping them develop across all areas.
- **Optimizes Learning:** A positive setting makes learning easier and more effective, allowing students to reach their full potential.
- **Strengthens Relationships:** It builds strong connections between children and their teachers, as well as with their families and the wider community.
- **Fosters Trust and Cooperation:** Such an environment nurtures a culture where everyone trusts each other and works well together.
- **Connects with Nature:** Bringing natural elements into the learning space helps children build a relationship with nature, making them more environmentally aware and sensitive.
- **Embraces Diversity:** Creating inclusive spaces teaches students not just to accept differences, but to celebrate diversity and develop tolerance.

Ultimately, a well-designed and positive learning environment doesn't just lead to better academic results. It also helps students mature, feel responsible, become valuable members of society, and develop into well-rounded individuals.

**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 3.6**

Analyse the class situation and explain if such a class is given to you, how would you teach this class. What changes you would like to bring in this class? How would you deal with parents of children to bring about any changes?

Ms. Varma is a highly experienced teacher of Class III in City Primary School, revered for her strict discipline and thorough coverage of the curriculum. Her classroom is always tidy, reflects a very disciplined pedagogical approach. Desks are arranged in neat rows, facing a large blackboard. Walls display standard, academic charts from years past. Natural light is minimal, and there's little evidence of student-created work or interactive displays.



Ms Varma's teaching relies heavily on lectures, rote memorization, and individual seatwork. She prides herself with the written work of children and the parents are also happy that the children's notebooks are complete and checked regularly. She primarily uses textbooks and the blackboard. Assessment is almost exclusively through written tests, spelling drills, and arithmetic worksheets, with emphasis on correct answers rather than understanding or process.

Ms Verma firmly believes in strict discipline and so there's little to no group work, project-based learning, or outdoor activities. She believes such methods are a waste of time.

The students of her class don't speak on their own, they are also shy to speak in front of a gathering or during assembly. They look for answers from the teachers and are not confident of thinking on their own. They think that students are not to speak in class.



3.6 LET US SUM UP

Therefore, we can say that Learning Environment plays an extremely important role in the overall education scenario. The learning environment, as explained above, has to be inviting, engaging and children need to feel a connection. The learning environment is far more than just a classroom; it's the entire ecosystem that shapes a child's educational journey. It encompasses critical, interconnected dimensions: As educators, we need to ensure that all components of children's learning environment i.e. the Physical environment (consisting of the Indoor and Outdoor environment), the Psychological, the Social, the Cultural and the Pedagogical environment is based on solid philosophical and psychological principles. When these dimensions are thoughtfully designed and positively cultivated, the learning environment becomes a dynamic space that not only optimises academic learning but also contributes to a child's holistic development, nurturing their self-concept, social-emotional skills, and sense of belonging, ultimately shaping them into well-rounded, responsible, and empathetic individuals.



3.7 END EXERCISES

1. Explain the concept of Learning Environment in brief:
2. What are the main components of a Learning Environment?



3. How is the psychological environment different from the Social and Cultural environment?
4. What is the role of the teacher in designing an effective and positive learning environment?

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